

FASHION ICON

BEAU BRUMMELL



△ CURLS AND CRAVAT

This engraving of a young Beau Brummell was taken from an original portrait miniature. He is not yet quite the peerless dandy, but his cravat is immaculate.

Routinely dismissed as a shallow fop, George Bryan ("Beau") Brummell was far more than the fashion arbiter for Regency England. The first true dandy, and enormously influential, he helped to overturn men's fashions in the early 1800s and pave the way for modern menswear. He also became an archetypal, appearance-obsessed star in a celebrity-crazed age – a phenomenon still familiar today. Brummell developed a close friendship with George, Prince of Wales (the Prince Regent and later King George IV), and became fashion and etiquette adviser to the prince and his court. His influence spread widely both in England and France.

Modern menswear

Said to have been tall and fair, Brummell probably justified his nickname. His fastidiousness means that he is often seen as the instigator of overly fussy fashions, but the reverse is true. Eighteenth-century aristocratic menswear included lavish fabrics, white stockings, ruffles and buckles, three-cornered hats, and scent. Fashions were simplifying by Brummell's time, but he cemented and extended this trend, sweeping obvious fussiness aside in favour of sombre-coloured, elegant restraint.

Brummell's bold simplicity was a take on the English country gentleman's sporting gear, and fitted with the neoclassical revolutionary spirit of the era. It featured a plain white linen shirt, immaculately bleached and starched; a fitted, pale waistcoat; a short-fronted, double-breasted, swallow-tailed woollen coat, dark blue or black; fitted pantaloon trousers rather than knee breeches; a white linen neckcloth tied showily (Brummell often fastened it in a "waterfall" of flowing layers);

and a top hat. Brass coat buttons were the only gaudy detail. This type of outfit had become standard by the 1820s and 30s, and what Brummell popularized with his trousers-jacket-flamboyant neckwear combination was none other than the original modern suit and tie.

Brummell's clean look also included close-cropped curls and a freshly washed face. He rejected scent because he washed daily, which was rare in Regency times. Scrupulous personal grooming was part of his code of etiquette, built on poise, excellence, and attention to detail. Brummell had his boots polished with champagne and rejected piles of neckclothes while dressing, until the creases fell in just the right place. One literary caricature based on Brummell suggests he was so fussy about perfect cut that one glover made the hands of his gloves, another the fingers, and a third one the thumbs.

Striking a pose

Dandyism is also an attitude of mind. Brummell affected a studied indifference, as if his simpler look was effortless (this parallels modern "cool" and the Chanel ethos – Coco was called "the female Beau Brummell").

Behind the façade of nonchalance, it took Brummell about six hours to get ready.

Attitude was underpinned by expert cut and fit. Thanks to advances in textile-making during Brummell's lifetime, more flexible wool cloth was produced. It made a neatly cut fit much easier to achieve than in previous generations.

Brummell's fashion influence helped to establish London as the centre of men's tailoring. His reputation for impeccable quality inspired Charles Worth, Aquascutum, and Tommy Nutter of Savile Row. In attitude and style, the dandy has lived on in Mick Jagger's 1960s and 70s suited look and more recently in Karl Lagerfeld's personal wardrobe.



PORTRAIT OF BRUMMELL, 1805 ▷

Robert Dighton's painting shows Brummell in his famous daytime ensemble, complete with tasselled boots.

TIMELINE

1778 Born in London

1790 Goes to school at Eton College, Windsor, where his fashion interest is soon obvious

1794–98 Short military career. Starts to develop as a true dandy

▷ 1799 Influence on men's fashion grows. Sets up Mayfair home, and career as fashion arbiter takes off

1812 Falls out with Prince Regent as a result of his sharp tongue

◁ 1816 Flees to France to escape creditors. Fashion influence on the wane

1840 Dies in an asylum in Caen in northwestern France

1835 Imprisoned for debt

○ 1780

○ 1790

○ 1800

○ 1810

○ 1820

○ 1830

○ 1840

